



During pregnancy, your body goes through myriad **changes** that influence your emotional and physical **well-being**. There's more than just the **stretching** of your belly as the uterus grows; **you might notice** changes to skin, hair, feet, nails, and teeth, not to mention parts of the body you can't see.

Physical and emotional changes

How you change physically

Some of the physical changes that occur to your body during pregnancy might be ones that you are happy with; for example, you might enjoy having a fuller bust, more rounded hips, thick, glossy hair, and a translucent sheen to the skin. Other changes, though, such as stretch marks, may be less welcome and can feel like unpleasant side effects. You may also find that the arch of your foot drops and that you go up a shoe size, which may be a permanent change. Not all women experience all of these changes, but however you're affected, try to keep in mind that they're positive signs that your pregnancy is progressing. Almost without exception, changes to your skin, hair, and nails will reverse once your baby is born.

Understanding your hormones

All the changes that take place in your body during pregnancy are the result of messages that your hormones send to your brain. Pregnancy hormones affect you both physically—changing your body and helping your baby to develop—and emotionally, too. Pregnancy is known for triggering mood swings, and your hormones, combined

with a heavy dash of fatigue and probably some anxiety, are to blame. If you have a partner, these moods may take a toll on him or her; make sure the two of you stay connected and find ways to both enjoy pregnancy. It is worthwhile to learn about pregnancy hormones and how they affect your emotions. Then having a few strategies that help avoid arguments and allow you to express your feelings constructively will help to steer you through the emotional minefield of this amazing time.

The hidden changes

If the outward signs of pregnancy and the hormonal changes weren't enough to come to grips with, there are lots of internal changes taking place that you may not even notice, but which are essential for nourishing your baby and maintaining your pregnancy. As you'll see, being pregnant affects the functioning of all your internal organs—your heart and liver have to work harder, and your lungs have to adapt to increase their efficiency in a much-reduced space. Within your breasts, long before your baby is born, changes take place that turn them into perhaps the most efficient food source we know of.